

Mental maps & collective narratives

What this tool produces · *Visual representations of internalized spatial boundaries, inventories of sensory assets, and maps highlighting areas of high emotional or historical attachment.*

G1 · Proof of Impact

Dimensions

Heritage

Spatial

Social / User

Preparing the workshop · *Mental maps & collective narratives*

G1 · Proof of Impact

Why this tool matters

Making the invisible visible: transforming a geography of concrete and asphalt into a living emotional landscape where the scars and joys of a community can be read.

Evidence we produce

Visual representations of internalized spatial boundaries, inventories of sensory assets, and maps highlighting areas of high emotional or historical attachment.

Duration & Material

Duration · 1 hour of guided walking, 1.5 hours of collaborative mapping

Material · Blank base maps, colored markers, sensory/feeling cards, tokens

Reference case

The Co-gnito participatory physicalization game uses storytelling and "feeling cards" to map subjective spatial experiences. It highlights how different groups remember the history of a space and negotiate its scale. Additionally, in the historic city of Canterbury, mental maps recensored acoustic and visual experiences to offer urbanists a taxonomy of sensory assets to preserve.

Suggested agenda · Brief (10 min) > Method walk-through (15 min) > Animation canvas (60-90 min) > Harvest (20 min)

Sensory walk → collective mental map

Duration
1 hour of guided walking, 1.5 hours of collaborative ma...

Blank base map

Each participant draws their personal route + sensory experiences + memory anchors



Sound

where the city is loud / quiet



Smell

pleasant or oppressive scents



Memory

places where past lingers



Comfort

where you feel held / held back



Discomfort

where you change pace

Merge individual sketches into a single collective map · reveal the shared emotional landscape.

Harvesting our *learnings*

After running the canvas, capture three layers of insight.

What inspires me

Stand-out signals, surprising stories, ideas to remember

How to apply it here

Concrete adaptations to our context, our team, our constraints

What we need to be autonomous

Skills, allies, resources, decisions still to secure

Each participant fills a copy. Then debrief together to surface patterns and next steps.